

Shamet off the Bench 3.0™

2025-26 Season Preview

Finn Irving

It was the late summer of 2023, where we gathered as a family at Nana and Granddad's house, likely to all celebrate being together once more before I ventured off to UVA. The dinner was like any other; filled with cheerful banter, a delicious meal, and likely some odd competition or statistic with way too many rules from Granddad. The 2023-24 NBA season was not on the near horizon, nor was the dust from Free Agency settled quite yet. But, as I like to do, I had been spending time on Twitter and other sites, formulating my opinions on the upcoming season. One tweet about the Washington Wizards roster had caught my eye. I'd formulated an opinion I felt like sharing. So, in the midst of dinner, I declared what will likely go down in the history books as **the most famous prediction I make in all my life**, joining hall of fame predictions by Uncle Jimmy such as "Peyton Manning, Tim Duncan and Victor Wembanyama will be busts." I said something along the lines of - "The Washington Wizards will make the playoffs this season. I quite like their roster, they've got Tyus Jones, Jordan Poole, Deni Avdija, Kyle Kuzma, and Daniel Gafford!" Then, most importantly of all, I bolstered my claim by stating, "They even have **SHAMET off the Bench™!**" The hysteria that ensued was like none I have ever seen in my life. Jack, Eli, Dave, and Jimmy all doubled over, slapping the table, absolutely dying laughing at the statement I had just said. I don't remember any other details about that get together, but that memory will be forever etched into my mind. In that scenario, most people will back down from their claim, unable to deal with having the unpopular opinion. I loved it... felt I would most definitely be correct, and my faith in the Wizards remained steadfast.

In order to back my claim, I decided to do a full-scale NBA season preview, which was naturally titled: "Shamet off the Bench™." The Wizards held the 9-seed in my predictions, with the following write-up: *"Here they are. The reason I am doing these rankings. The Washington Wizards. I uttered those famous words – "Shamet off the Bench™" ... and I will stand by them all year long. This team will make the playoffs. I firmly believe it. Jordan Poole is certainly a flawed player, but I think he will thrive in an environment where he can shoot it as frequently as he pleases. He was hamstrung a bit in the Golden State offense, where he was not top dog, or even second top dog. While he may be inefficient at times, he can light it up, and I predict he will score nearly 30 ppg. Kuzma is another player who can score the ball in great volumes. I love their addition of Tyus Jones. I think he has been the best backup PG in the league for several years. Here, he will step into a starting spot, and I believe he will thrive. He has led the league in assist/turnover ratio for 5 consecutive seasons. Other players such as Corey Kispert, Daniel Gafford, Deni Avdija, and Delon Wright will all be serviceable role players for the team. And of course, lastly, you have the one and only Landry Shamet. That is the secret weapon of this Wizards team. His services will be unparalleled. He has a career winning percentage of .649 and*

will bring his winning ways to Washington and change the culture. Mark my words... this team will make the playoffs."

Obviously, that did not come close to happening. The Wizards went 15-67, spared being the embarrassment of the NBA only by the Detroit Pistons and their 28-game losing streak. As a reward for their egregiously bad season, they were rewarded the #2 pick and Alex Sarr... yippee! Nonetheless, it was a remarkably memorable season in our eyes. Last year, I compiled a bigger and better Shamet off the Bench 2.0, even with Landry Shamet languishing on the Injured List or in the G-League for most of the season. Through 2 years, my predictions have been largely terrible. Some notable lowlights include predicting the eventual Western Conference champion Dallas Mavericks to finish 13th in the West in 2023-24, picking the New Orleans Pelicans to finish 3rd in the West last year (21-61 final record), having great faith in the Raptors and future superstar Grady Dick to make the playoffs last year (which resulted in my unfortunate losing punishment of consuming 16.7 circus peanuts... about 14.7 more than anyone should ever have), and then of course the 2023-24 Wizards fiasco.

Despite this, I enter into Shamet off the Bench 3.0 with renewed vim and vigor. I have further enhanced the season preview, adding some new things throughout. Whether this third iteration of predictions will turn out better than the first two years, I cannot say. All I know is that I will stick with my predictions to the bitter end.

At the time of writing this, superstar Landry Shamet has just signed a one-year deal to return to the New York Knicks. There, he will be fighting for the last roster spot against well-known UVA legend Malcolm Brogdon and lesser-known Lipscomb legend Garrison Matthews. I hope future 3x Coach of the Year Mike Brown makes the right decision and keeps Shamet. Otherwise... to quote Uncle Jimmy on 7/7/24... "Brace yourself for becoming a fan of Maccabi Tel Aviv or Hapoel Jerusalem."

Here's to a wonderful 2025-26 NBA Season!

- Esteemed Author of Shamet off the Bench™ Finn Irving



Projected Standings

Eastern Conference

1. **New York Knicks**
2. **Cleveland Cavaliers**
3. **Atlanta Hawks**
4. **Indiana Pacers**
5. **Orlando Magic**
6. **Miami Heat**
7. **Detroit Pistons**
8. **Boston Celtics**
9. **Toronto Raptors**
10. Milwaukee Bucks
11. Charlotte Hornets
12. Philadelphia 76ers
13. **Chicago Bulls**
14. **Washington Wizards**
15. **Brooklyn Nets**

Western Conference

1. **Oklahoma City Thunder**
2. **Denver Nuggets**
3. **Houston Rockets**
4. **Minnesota Timberwolves**
5. Dallas Mavericks
6. Golden State Warriors
7. Los Angeles Lakers
8. Los Angeles Clippers
9. San Antonio Spurs
10. **Sacramento Kings**
11. **Memphis Grizzlies**
12. **Phoenix Suns**
13. **New Orleans Pelicans**
14. **Portland Trailblazers**
15. **Utah Jazz**

East

#1 – New York Knicks

General Thoughts – In a remarkably weak Eastern Conference, I believe the Knicks are the best team. I don't think Mike Brown is a better coach than Thibodeau, but he won't run this roster into the ground during the regular season by playing the starters 45 min a game. Brown said he expects to have a 9 to 10-man rotation, which should allow the team to be healthier and a more potent playoff threat. Their starting lineup is the exact same as last year, but their bench is much improved. Big Meech played only 17 games last year and 31 in 2023-24. If he can stay healthy throughout the season, that is a huge boost for their team. In addition, they added Jordan Clarkson, who is a better second unit scorer than a starter and Guerschon Yabusele (who signed a team friendly 2 year, 12-million-dollar deal), an upgrade over Precious Achiuwa, providing a much more versatile game off the bench. Expect their offense to look very different this season. Brown likes to run and gun, which is a stark contrast from Thibodeau's old fashioned grit and grind mentality. I am not entirely sure how this will work with Brunson's old man game, but I think it will greatly benefit Bridges, Anunoby and Towns. I will talk more about Towns below, but I think he will absolutely thrive in this system and is a dark-horse MVP candidate. I think this team improved upon last year's roster but their rise to the #1 seed is more a byproduct of what has happened to all the teams around them. Still, I think they are my favorite to emerge from the Eastern Conference, could square off against a Western Conference team that is much more battered from conference playoffs, and win the title. Also, don't forget – They've got Shamet off the Bench™!

Projected Starters

PG: Jalen Brunson

SG: Mikal Bridges

SF: Josh Hart

PF: OG Anunoby

C: Karl-Anthony Towns



Key Bench Players: Mitchell "Big Meech" Robinson, Jordan Clarkson, Guerschon "The Dancing Bear" Yabusele

Head Coach – Mike Brown

Additions – Guerschon "The Dancing Bear" Yabusele, Jordan Clarkson

Losses – Precious Achiuwa

Breakout Candidate – Karl-Anthony Towns: This is a tricky one, as his numbers took a big leap last season. But like I said, I think he is an MVP candidate this season. Last year, his 3pt attempts were the lowest they'd been since 2018-19. In an offense that will surely see an increase in possessions per game, I see him as the largest beneficiary. Also, his body should benefit from Mitchell Robinson being healthy. He had to play C all year last year and bang with the big boys inside (which he probably enjoyed, given his extreme zestiness). That shouldn't be the case this season, he should see ample time at the 4. I think he will score 28+ ppg this season and finish top 3 in MVP voting.

Draft Picks – No Notables

#2 – Cleveland Cavaliers

General Thoughts – Following a remarkably impressive regular season in coach Kenny Atkinson's rookie year, the Cavaliers bring back a similar roster. This was a team I did not think was championship caliber going into last year, and I once again I feel this way. Donovan Mitchell is simply not a good enough #1 option for a winning team. For a team plagued by injuries in the past, they were fortunate last year (Garland 75, Mitchell 71, Mobley 71, Allen 82). Garland is already injured to start the season, and I expect their general injury fortune to regress to the mean this year. They still have an excellent team; I especially love their big man tandem of Mobley and Allen. Mobley took home the Defensive Player of the Year award last year and Allen averaged nearly a steal and block per game. One move they made this offseason that was particularly perplexing to me was the signing of Sam Merrill to a 4-year, \$38 million dollar contract. This seemed like an exorbitant amount of money to give Merrill... and then they let Ty Jerome walk, where he signed with Memphis for 3 years, \$28 million. Jerome is a far better player than Merrill in my unbiased eyes, so to sign Merrill for more years and more money? Definitely odd to me. Plus, in my biased eyes, I wanted to see De'Andre Hunter and Ty Jerome share the court as Cavaliers some more. All in all, I think that you can expect the Cavaliers to do exactly what they have done in the last few years. Win a fair number of games, finish as a high seed (especially in a decimated Eastern Conference), but then make a fairly early exit in the playoffs. Without the addition of a larger superstar, I just don't think they have the juice to go further than the second round.

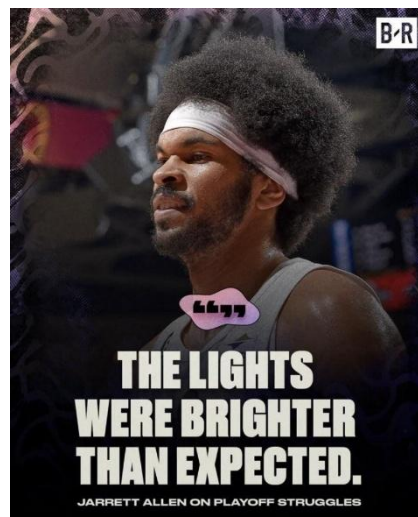
Projected Starters

PG: Lonzo Ball

SG: Donovan Mitchell

SF: De'Andre Hunter

PF: Evan Mobley



C: Jarrett Allen

Key Bench Players: Sam Merrill, Dean Wade, Larry Nance Jr.

Head Coach – Kenny Atkinson

Additions – Lonzo Ball, Larry Nance Jr., Thomas Bryant

Losses – Isaac Okoro, Ty Jerome

Notable Injuries – Darius Garland will miss several weeks to open the season following toe surgery. Max Strus is eyeing a December return after a foot fracture.

Breakout Candidate – Jaylon Tyson: There's a decent chance you have no clue who this is. Tyson is a 6'6" 215 SG/SF and was the 20th pick in 2024; a product of the California Golden Bears. He received very little playing time last season, but had a few strong performances when given the opportunity (16/11/7 on November 20th and 31/7/4 on April 13th). He showed throughout his college career that he could really score the rock. The Cavaliers enter the season with a very thin guard room, after offseason injuries to Darius Garland and Max Strus, along with the departures of Isaac Okoro and Ty Jerome. Tyson should be given a chance to prove himself in the first 6-8 weeks of the season, and could solidify himself as a bonafide member of their rotation if he plays well (similar to what Ty Jerome did for them last season).

Draft Picks – (49) Tyrese Proctor

#3 – Atlanta Hawks

General Thoughts – You know the East is weak when I'm penciling in the Atlanta Hawks at the #3 seed, but I really do like the roster they've built. Firstly, their team is enormous. 14/15 players on their roster are 6'5" or taller, 11/15 are 6'8" or taller. In a time where length and athleticism are coveted above all else, they have it in spades. Dyson Daniels broke out in a huge way, swiping 3.0 steals a game, the first time that had happened since Alvin Robertson in 1990-91! I have to give myself a bit of credit here; I am not often correct in my predictions, but I was all over Daniels to breakout last season. I guess a broken clock is right twice a day! Jalen Johnson was putting up huge numbers once more before tearing his labrum in January and missing the entire second half. Their big addition to the starting lineup was Kristaps Porzingis, who they acquired from the Celtics while giving up very little, especially for a player of his caliber. When he's right, Porzingis is one of the most talented bigs in the league, and could form a dynamic duo with Trae Young. However, he seems to always be injured, and missed time in the playoffs in 2025 with some mystery illness (which my Twitter feed was wholeheartedly convinced was AIDS...). If the Johnson/Porzingis tandem can stay on the court, it could truly take this team to another level. Risacher has to be the least exciting #1 pick ever, but actually put up 15 ppg on 41% 3pt shooting in the 2nd half, and won't be asked to do any more than that this

season. They bolstered their bench by adding lockdown defender Nickeil Alexander-Walker and the most underrated shooter in the NBA Luke Kennard (43% or better from three in FIVE straight seasons!) I really do like this roster. I think it is explosive, balanced and deep. It also has more playoff experience than you would think. I think the Hawks could really surprise some people and may even have an ECF run in them!

Projected Starters

PG: Trae Young

SG: Dyson Daniels

SF: Zaccharie Risacher

PF: Jalen Johnson

C: Kristaps Porzingis

Key Bench Players: Onyeka Okongwu, Luke Kennard, Nickeil Alexander-Walker

Head Coach – Quin Snyder

Additions – Nickeil Alexander-Walker, Kristaps Porzingis, Luke Kennard

Losses – Clint Capela, Terrance Mann, Georges Niang, Caris LeVert

Breakout Candidate – Onyeka Okongwu: For years Okongwu has been stuffed behind Clint Capela on the Hawks depth chart. With Capela finally gone, he should be their starting center all season. To date, Okongwu has started only 76 of 307 career games. He actually had a very solid season last year, averaging 13.4 pts and 8.9 reb, along with nearly a steal and block per game (0.9 of each). He has been rumored as a breakout player for several years now, but this year he has by far the clearest path to doing so. I think he will pair well with Tingus Pingus, as despite being a true C, Okongwu is only 6'8" (7 ft 2 wingspan). The duality of talents between the two bigs should benefit each, and should leave one with an advantageous matchup. I don't foresee any breakout of titanic proportions, but I think he could reach 15 pts, 10 reb and 1.3 blocks a game. And don't sleep on the big man's 3-ball! He ventured out behind the line for 2.0 threes attempted a game last year! (32.4%)

Draft Picks – (23) Asa Newell



#4 – Indiana Pacers

General Thoughts – I still really like this team, even with the loss of Tyrese Haliburton to injury and Myles Turner to free agency. Haliburton is a great player, but the Pacers had the best backup point guards in the league in Nembhard and McConnell. Both have always done wonderfully when filling in for Haliburton in the past, I see no reason why they can't do the

same this year. To replace Turner, they traded (2 second round picks) for a beloved figure in the Irving Household, Jay Huff! Heck, our fantasy basketball league is named “Jay Huff for President” we love the guy so much. Also, a little brag, I was lucky enough to meet and rebound for Jay Huff last summer. He is just your normal down-to-earth and friendly guy! He actually came up to me and introduced himself, “Hi there, I’m Jay!” Inside I was thinking (1. This is freaking awesome and 2. Trust me, I know who you are!) Anyways, Huff finally gained an opportunity to play in Memphis last season and did really well. Shocker... the 7’1” guy who can shoot 40% from three is effective! Huff will get the first shot at the starting center position, and should fit extremely well into the run and gun system that Indiana runs. They bring back their entire interchangeable army of G/F players in Mathurin, Nesmith, Sheppard, Siakam, and Toppin. Siakam will likely be asked to be the #1 guy on offense this season. He is remarkably consistent game to game (2024-25 Finn’s fantasy team member) and has put up 20+ ppg in six straight seasons now... wow! Rick Carlisle is an excellent coach; one could champion for him as the best in the league and I would not argue at all. They will attack teams with their strength once more this season: Depth and Speed. Despite not having as much star-power, they should still be a force in the Eastern Conference, and I see no reason why they couldn’t make a run to the Conference Finals or dare I say even further.

Projected Starters

PG: Andrew Nembhard

SG: Bennedict Mathurin

SF: Aaron Nesmith

PF: Pascal Siakam

C: Jay Huff



Key Bench Players: Obi Toppin, T.J. McConnell, Ben Sheppard

Head Coach – Rick Carlisle

Additions – Jay Huff

Losses – Myles Turner

Notable Injury – Tyrese Haliburton will miss the entire season following a Game 7 torn Achilles.

Breakout Candidate – Bennedict Mathurin: Some teams I have to stretch to find a breakout candidate, but this team has several. Mathurin to me just squeaked out Nembhard and Huff (Huff primarily because I wrote so much about him above). With the Pacers great depth, Mathurin has seen somewhat inconsistent minutes and opportunities. Carlisle liked to run Hali/Nembhard at his two guard spots. This year though, Mathurin should start every game, and I think he will be the #2 option on offense. I’d project his points to jump to about 20 per game

(16.1 in 2024-25), his 3's to increase to 2 per game (1.4 in 2024-25) and shot attempts to be around 15 (11.8 in 2024-25). Mathurin is one of those guys who can get on a real heater, and with a higher usage rate, he should be able to get hot more often!

Draft Picks – (38) Kam Jones

#5 – Orlando Magic

General Thoughts – Last year was likely not Orlando's favorite of all time. Their promising young core was ravaged by injuries, with Banchemo, Suggs and Wagner all missing extended periods of time (somehow both Banchemo and Wagner tore their obliques... odd coincidence). Priority #1 this season is for those guys to all be on the court together. They went out and made a big move in the offseason, trading 4 first round picks for Desmond Bane. I am not super high on Bane, and I know Jack is even less high on him. However, he is a very good shooter (2.6 3's per game on 41% 3pt for his career), which has been a real weakness of Orlando's in the past few seasons. Filling out their starting lineup is Wendell Carter Jr. who I only included because I wanted to note that he is dating Angel Reese (YUCK!). Their bench crew remains largely the same, with the additions of rookie Jase Richardson and perennial backup PG Tyus Jones. I have always been a big fan of Jones, I think he is one of the best backup guards in the league, so to get him on a 1 year \$7 mil deal was an excellent signing. Aside from UVA and UC San Diego, I probably watched the third most Michigan State basketball last year, where I thought Richardson was a phenomenal player. I'm not sure if he will translate to the NBA super well, but I will be rooting for him. This team has a lot of upside, but also a lot of moving pieces that need to all come together for them to reach their full potential. Players being injury-prone is often not a "bad luck" scenario, but rather a systematic failure. Should they stay healthy this year, and Bane acclimate himself well to their roster, they could be one of the best 2 teams in the East, with Conference Finals potential.

Projected Starters

PG: Jalen Suggs

SG: Desmond Bane

SF: Franz Wagner

PF: Paolo Banchemo

C: Wendell Carter Jr.

Key Bench Players: Goga Bitadze, Tyus Jones, Moe Wagner

Head Coach – Jamahl Mosley

Additions – Desmond Bane, Tyus Jones



Losses – Kentavious Caldwell-Pope, Gary Harris, Cole Anthony

Breakout Candidate – Jalen Suggs: I fully believe Suggs was in the process of breaking out last season before he got injured. Even while shooting horribly from the field (41.0% FG, 31.4% 3PT), his production had increased in every major stat category. He shot much better the year before, albeit on less shot attempts. By adding Bane to the mix though, I think Suggs will get less attention, which should allow him to shoot better. The Bane addition impacts him twofold though, as I do think his shots will plateau about where they were last year (13.7 per game). He is one of the best “Stocks” guys in the league, averaging 1.5 steals and 0.9 blocks per game last year, and making Second-Team All Defense in 2023-24. As the defensive anchor and point guard of this team, it is paramount that he stays healthy and shoots the ball better. I can’t guarantee his health, but I think if he is out there, he will have a big season for the Magic.

Draft Picks – (25) Jase Richardson, (32) Noah Penda

#6 – Miami Heat

General Thoughts – Of all the teams in the league, I certainly would not have guessed it would be the roster of the Miami Heat that I would find enticing. If not for the injury to Tyler Herro, I might have put them in the top 4. Usually, the Heat are a team that makes the most out of a limited amount of talent. This roster possesses a lot of talent, and is quite deep. Bam Adebayo is one of my favorite players; he does absolutely everything for a team. He even added a three ball to his game last season, making 1.0 per game. Herro does not get enough credit for being an elite talent and one of the best shooters in the game. Norman Powell and Andrew Wiggins are both veteran players and gifted scorers who I think really deepen the offensive capabilities of this team. Wiggins averaged 19 ppg in his short Miami tenure last season, and Powell averaged a career high 21.8 in Los Angeles. Having four legitimate 20 ppg scorers in a starting lineup is remarkable. To balance out this starting lineup, they have the LVP Nikola Jovic penciled in at PF. While he is a fine player, I would much rather see Bam at the 4 and then Kel’el Ware at the 5. In 36 games as a starter last year, Ware averaged a double-double (10.8/10.0) and also added 1.3 bpg. Regardless of whether he starts or comes off the bench, I expect him to have a big impact on this team. To fill out their bench they have Davion Mitchell (filling in at PG while Herro is out), Terry Rozier (unless he gets banned for gambling), Jaime Jacquez Jr and my favorite rookie Kasparas Jakucionis. That is a lot of talent on the bench! I watched a lot of Illinois basketball because I thought Jakucionis was awesome and am hoping that he will get opportunities to prove himself on this roster. Miami was pretty terrible last year, and before I started writing this, I figured it would be more of the same. But I am super impressed by this roster and think they could push as high as the #3 seed in the East if things go their way. Plus, they have Erik Spoelstra, who is the consensus best coach in the NBA. That’s always going to make me believe in them a little extra.

Projected Starters

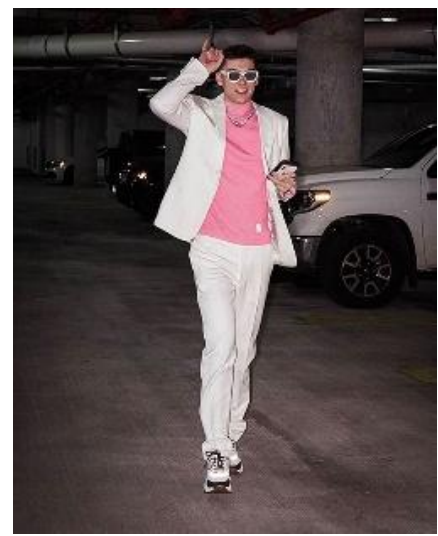
PG: Davion Mitchell

SG: Norman Powell

SF: Andrew Wiggins

PF: LVP Nikola Jovic

C: Bam Adebayo



Key Bench Players: Kel’el Ware, Dru Smith, Jaime Jacquez Jr. (Special inclusion Terry Rozier who may or may not be suspended for gambling on/throwing games)

Head Coach – Erik Spoelstra

Additions – Norman Powell, Simone Fontecchio, Precious Achiuwa

Losses – Duncan Robinson, Haywood Highsmith, Kyle “Slo-Mo” Anderson

Key Injury – Tyler Herro is expected to miss eight weeks after undergoing foot surgery.

Breakout Candidate – Dru Smith: This is maybe another name that you have not heard of. As of now, Smith is somewhat buried on Miami’s depth chart. However, I do not think that will end up being the case as the season progresses. The undrafted free agent was just starting to receive consistent minutes last year when he devastatingly tore his Achilles. In the six games prior to that, he was playing 29.3 mpg and scored 10.3 ppg, made 1.8 threes per game, and swiped 2.5 steals per game. That steals number is the primary reason why I think he can be a big contributor. He is a defense-first player who does not require the ball in his hands. On a roster that has a lot of guys who are going to put up shots and score points, he could be a perfect complement. If he gets minutes, expect him to perform well, and pick up a lot of steals!

Draft Picks – (20) Kasparas Jakucionis

#7 – Detroit Pistons

General Thoughts – Last year I finished the Pistons write-up by saying “Their new coach, JB Bickerstaff, will look to make lemonade out of lemons, but man oh man, life has given him some sour lemons.” I’d placed them directly in the 15th spot in the East. To my great surprise, JB Bickerstaff made some excellent lemonade. Detroit went 44-38 and was the 6-seed in the East. They are led by Cade Cunningham, who took a great leap forward last season, putting up tremendous numbers (26.1/6.1/9.1). Tobias Harris fit in nicely, Jalen Duren stayed healthy all year, and Ausar Thompson started to emerge as a weapon as the year went on. Detroit comes back this season with a similar looking roster. A couple offseason moves were made, but they were largely lateral. Caris LeVert has played for Bickerstaff in Cleveland before, so clearly, he was

someone that the coach trusts and wanted on his squad. Duncan Robinson, who they acquired in a sign-and-trade with Miami, directly replaces Tim Hardaway on the team as a shooter off the bench. The most important addition this team gets is Jaden Ivey. Ivey only played 30 games last year after breaking his leg on New Years' Day, but returns fully healthy this season. He is a player whom I really like, and was shooting a career high 40.9% from 3pt land prior to his injury. Ron Holland played in 81 games as a rookie, but did not have a huge impact, playing only 15.6 mpg and putting up menial numbers. A sophomore leap from him would improve what is a talented, but somewhat unathletic bench. This team utterly shocked me last season, and has a roster talented enough to replicate their performance. I would be surprised to see them take another leap, and my best estimate is that their record will be similar to last season, landing them in the 5-8 seed range.

Projected Starters

PG: Cade Cunningham

SG: Jaden Ivey

SF: Ausar Thompson

PF: Tobias Harris

C: Jalen Duren



Key Bench Players: Caris LeVert, Ron Holland, Duncan Robinson

Head Coach – JB Bickerstaff

Additions – Duncan Robinson, Caris LeVert

Losses – Tim Hardaway Jr., Dennis Schroder, Simone Fontecchio

Breakout Candidate – Ausar Thompson: Last year I was all aboard the Amen Thompson breakout train, and it most certainly happened. This year, I hopped right onto the Ausar breakout train. He was injured off-and-on last year, which prevented him from ever truly settling in. The signs were there though. In 33 games from February-April, he averaged 11.8/5.5/2.8/1.8/0.8. There simply aren't other players in the NBA that look and move like the Thompson Twins do. In a league full of the best athletes in the world, they are at the top of the pyramid. Ausar is not as gifted on-ball as Amen, but will slot in as the starting SF for this team for the foreseeable future. Missing the start of the season can completely throw off a player's rhythm, which I think stunted Thompson's growth slightly last year. This year he is ready to go, and I expect him to cause chaos right away, being the Pistons' best defender and putting up well-balanced stat lines.

Draft Picks – (37) Chaz Lanier

#8 – Boston Celtics

General Thoughts – Boy can the times change quickly. Going into the playoffs last year, it seemed as though the Celtics were the favorites to repeat as champions, and a burgeoning dynasty was underway. Then, Jayson Tatum tore his Achilles in Game 4 of the Eastern Conference Semifinals, the Knicks defeated them in 6, and suddenly their 2025-26 season looked much different. I would like to preface this by saying that I certainly think that the Celtics will be right back at the top of the East for the next several years. However, this year has turned weird for them, and this roster is not the caliber we have seen from them over the past few seasons. For starters, their big men are awful. Their starting frontcourt of Sam Hauser and Neemias Queta is not inspiring. But who else is there to sub in? The Slim Duck? Xavier Tillman? Luka Garza? Not good. They still have Derrick White and Jaylen Brown, both of whom will need to do a bit more offensively in the absence of Tatum. In the offseason, they dealt a rapidly waning Jrue Holiday to the Trailblazers and got Anfernee Simons in return. Not only did this shed \$8 million in salary, but Simons is a free agent at the end of the season and Holiday had 2 more years (plus this one). I would almost guarantee Simons to be traded mid-season. He is not a good player, but was an advantageous deal for Boston and can serve as a stopgap for Tatum for the time being. Payton Pritchard still serves as dynamite off the bench following his 6th man of the year award. He can heave up his halfcourt shots with even more gusto now since they no longer count as a missed shot attempt for the player, just the team (a good NBA write-up includes all facets of the off-season... even some rule changes!) I have heard rumors via Twitter that Tatum received some new and innovative Achilles surgery, and that since he got the surgery the night of, he will be able to recover quicker than ever. As much as Tatum wants to be Kobe, I cannot imagine he will return this season. The Celtics would be foolish to rush their franchise cornerstone back to an average team that I do not think is a contender, even with a healthy Tatum. They would be better off simply eating this season and getting Tatum fully healthy for 2026-27, where they can contend once more.



Jeremy Hartman
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X.com

Oh, he hype now @paytonpritch3!
@JaxonHartman

Projected Starters

PG: Derrick White

SG: Anfernee Simons

SF: Jaylen Brown

PF: Sam Hauser

C: Neemias Queta



Key Bench Players: Payton Pritchard, Baylor Scheierman, Chris “Slim Duck” Boucher

Head Coach – Joe Mazzula

Additions – Anfernee Simons, Chris “Slim Duck” Boucher

Losses – Jrue Holiday, Kristaps Porzingis, Luke Kornet, Al Horford

Notable Injury – Jayson Tatum will miss pretty much all of the 2025-26 season with a torn achilles.

Breakout Candidate – Baylor Scheierman: I would guess the average person would pick Jaylen Brown to be the breakout guy in the absence of Tatum... but that's no fun! Scheierman received virtually no opportunities last season. This year however, he is slotted in as the backup SG and should see a healthy dose of playing time. The dude can shoot lights out, and is a tough shot maker. My belief in Scheierman runs deep. Every year I have a mid-major team I fall in love with, and in 2021-22 that was the South Dakota State Jackrabbits. Scheierman was their star, and what a star he was. He did it all, shooting a whopping 46.9% from three on 5.1 attempts a game and averaging 16.2/7.8/4.5. I very distinctly remember having a movie on TV with the girl I was dating at the time, but I was GLUED to my phone because my beloved 13-seeded Jackrabbits were taking on #4 seed Providence. I definitely had them in the Sweet 16 or Elite 8. The end result was that they lost a close one and I was sad... but I loved Scheierman then and I love him now. I think he will emerge as a sharpshooter off the Celtics bench, much like Sam Hauser did a few years ago.

Draft Picks – (28) Hugo Gonzalez

#9 – Toronto Raptors

General Thoughts – My placement of the Raptors in the #8 spot last season caused by subsequent feast of circus peanuts. I ended that video by saying "I hate the Raptors." Call me crazy, but I think they will be alright once again. They made a really savvy move in trading for and signing an injured Brandon Ingram last year at the deadline. He didn't play a game for them, but was the top FA in the impending 2025 class and they were able to lock him up for 3 years. The other 4 starters from last year are the same, and that starting lineup looks awfully appetizing to me. It is imperative that Immanuel Quickley stays healthy this season. He played only 33 games last season (screwing me over in fantasy after I reached for him in the 3rd round) including getting hurt in the very first game of the season. RJ Barrett is who he is, but he admittedly put up good numbers last year. Ole Scottie Barnes was unable to build on his breakout 23-24 season, with a slight downtick across the board. Worst 5 MVP Jakob Poeltl did not quite reach his gaudy simulation totals, but did put up a strong statline of 14.5/9.6 coupled with 1.2 steals and blocks per game. He was rewarded handsomely with a 4-year, \$105 million extension. Jakob Poeltl makes 100 million dollars simply for being an above-average big man... NBA money is stupid. Their bench is a little thin, but does contain Finn's absolute favorite Grady Dick. He was off to a rip-roaring start last season, averaging 17.6 ppg through 2024. However, the New year brought ill fortunes upon my superstar and he finished the season poorly and then injured. I'd like to make special note of their singular offseason move. They

signed Sandro Mamukelashvili to replace Chris Boucher. It is likely the most insignificant transaction of the year. I will admit I do not have grand visions for this squad like I did last year. However, I think they have some veteran scorers in a potent starting lineup, and can put together a middle-of-the-pack season.

Projected Starters

PG: Immanuel Quickley

SG: RJ Barrett

SF: Brandon Ingram

PF: Scottie Barnes

C: Jakob Poeltl

Key Bench Players: Gradey Dick, Collin Murray-Boyles, Ochai Agbaji

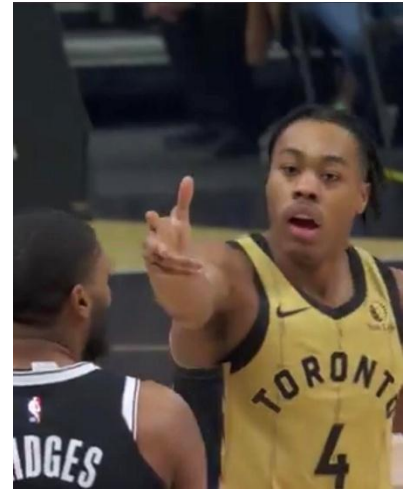
Head Coach – Darko Rajakovic

Additions – Sandro Mamukelashvili

Losses – Chris “Slim Duck” Boucher

Breakout Candidate – Immanuel Quickley: I was ALL IN on Quickley last season. I took him ridiculously early in our fantasy draft (40th overall). His season was so disjoint that despite him putting up decent numbers by his standards, it didn’t feel like it. I think he has the capability to be a 20 ppg scorer, or a 7.5-9.0 assist per game guy, depending on what his role is in their offense this season. He is an elite shooter who, with slightly refined shot selection, should be able to increase his percentages. I do not think his points and assists will both increase as such, given the high usage rate of other members of the starting lineup. However, I would expect one of those two values to take a leap this season, as Quickley looks to have a more complete season in Toronto.

Draft Picks – (9) Collin Murray-Boyles, (39) Alijah Martin



#10 – Milwaukee Bucks

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: Kevin Porter Jr.

SG: Gary Trent Jr.

SF: Kyle Kuzma



PF: Giannis Antetokounmpo

C: Myles Turner

Key Bench Players: Cole Anthony, Taurean Prince, Bobby Portis

Head Coach – Doc Rivers

Additions – Myles Turner, Gary Harris, Cole Anthony

Losses – Damian Lillard, Brook Lopez, Pat Connaughton

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks –

#11 – Charlotte Hornets

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: LaMelo Ball

SG: Kon Knueppel

SF: Brandon Miller

PF: Miles Bridges

C: Moussa Diabate



Key Bench Players: Collin Sexton, Ryan Kalkbrenner, Tre Mann

Head Coach – Charles Lee

- Mastermind of the famous “Charles Lee Timeout” called between free throws 1 and 2, usually in the first quarter.

Additions – Collin Sexton, Spencer Dinwiddie, Mason Plumlee, Pat Connaughton

Losses – Vasilije Micic, Mark Williams

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – (4) Kon Knueppel, (29) Liam McNeeley (33) Sion James, (34) Ryan Kalkbrenner

#12 – Philadelphia 76ers

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: Tyrese Maxey

SG: Quentin Grimes

SF: VJ Edgecombe

PF: Paul George

C: Joel Embiid

Key Bench Players: Adem Bona, Eric Gordon, Kelly Oubre Jr.

Head Coach – Nick Nurse

Additions – Trenderon Watford

Losses – Guerschon Yabusele, Jared Butler

Notable Injury -

Breakout Candidate – Jared McCain tore his UCL in his thumb and will miss 6-8 weeks.

Draft Picks – (3) VJ Edgecombe, (35) Johni Broome



#13 – Chicago Bulls

General Thoughts – Every year I do it, and this year my “Team I Least Want to Watch” award goes to the Chicago Bulls! This roster is just a wasteland for failed lottery picks. You’ve got Patrick Williams (4), Isaac Okoro (5), Josh Giddey (6), Coby White (7), Jalen Smith (10), and Zach Collins (10). Josh Giddey put up great stats last year, but they were empty stats on a terrible team... and the team that dealt him immediately won the championship. That tells me all I need to know about him. Coby White averaged 20 ppg in the most inconsistent manner ever (I had him on my fantasy team... it was infuriating). Nikola Vucevic simply still exists on their team and has put up identical stats for four straight seasons. They have a who’s who of randoms on their bench, most of whom they acquired as throw-ins from the LaVine trade. Trading LaVine rid them of a large chunk of salary, but they didn’t do anything with it. Matas Buzelis, their 2024 first round pick, showed promise in the second half last season (and also made a forgettable dunk contest appearance, where he failed to make a dunk on his first attempt, recording the participation trophy score of 40/50!) If they want to be good in the near future, they will need him to blossom into a star, coupled with Giddey, who they signed to a 4-year \$100 mil extension in the offseason. I don’t know about you, but I really can’t see that being a deadly duo for the future. The Bulls have been bad for a full decade now, having not won a playoff series since



2014-15, and making the playoffs only 1 of the last 8 seasons. They seem afraid to fully tear it down and tank, but also incapable of building a roster that is a true playoff threat. I see no world where this team makes the playoffs, and I know I won't be watching much Bulls basketball this year!

Projected Starters

PG: Josh "Still Lovin on them Youngins" Giddey*

SG: Coby White

SF: Ayo Dosunmu

PF: Matas Buzelis

C: Nikola Vučević

Key Bench Players: Tre Jones, Zach Collins, Isaac Okoro

- Giddey has one of my favorite nicknames in all of Basketball Reference - SLOB Wizard

Head Coach – Billy Donovan

- In the article ranking all NBA head coaches, this quote about Donovan stood out to me – *"Chicago has one playoff appearance under Donovan in five years. With the ownership group seemingly thrilled by this development, Donovan will logically remain as the head coach until the wheels completely fall off the wagon"*

Additions – Isaac Okoro

Losses – Lonzo Ball

Breakout Candidate – Matas Buzelis: This is an easy and popular breakout pick, if for no other reason than the fact that the Bulls have no other young player with potential on their roster. Buzelis did not see a lot of playing time early in the year, but started all 27 games after the all-star break, averaging 13.0 pts, 4.8 reb and 1.1 blocks with respectable shooting percentages (46.7/36.1/83.3). If Billy Donovan and Co. are smart, they will feature Buzelis heavily to see what kind of talent they truly have on their hands. I think he can put up numbers like what he did in the 2nd half of 2025 in the 1st half of 2025-26, and then hopefully in the 2nd half of 2026 that when the Bulls inevitably trade away some of their veterans.

Draft Picks – (12) Noa Essengue*

- I knew absolutely nothing about Noa Essengue when he was drafted. But during the summer league, he was on the receiving end of perhaps the most humiliating poster dunk in the history of basketball. By Johnny Furphy of all people!



#14 – Washington Wizards

General Thoughts – Here is Shamet off the Bench’s shining star once more. After putting together a tepid 18-64 record last year, hoping desperately for that #1 pick and Cooper Flagg, the Wizards were rewarded with the #6 overall pick instead. They had a surprisingly active off-season, most notably (and devastatingly) trading away my beloved Jordan Poole. This is the second time he has been traded away from me, and I’m starting to feel as though we are in a toxic relationship. In return they netted veteran CJ McCollum. Pairing him with Khris Middleton, they actually have some guys that can score the rock, along with two guys that should provide much-needed mentorship to their cadre of 18–20-year-olds. The Irving “Wizards Watch Parties” were probably my favorite memories of last season, and alongside those I probably watched 30 other Wizards games (much like eating circus peanuts, that is about 28 too many). Their rookie class from last season has some promise, but needs to show definite improvement this year. Alex Sarr simply CANNOT shoot 39.4% from the field as a 7-footer... that is utterly disgusting. He did average 1.5 blocks per game, proving to be a strong interior presence on defense. One move the Wiz made that I particularly liked was the acquisition of Cam Whitmore. He is an absolute microwave scorer, and should have some huge games off the bench... alongside some 4/15 games. Not that different from Jordan Poole! I know next-to-nothing about their draft pick Tre Johnson, so I will have to form my opinions on him by consuming some more Wizards basketball, brought to you courtesy of Chris Haynes, Drew Gooden, Wes Hall, Tony Massenburg, Meghan McPeak, and of course Greivis Vasquez! I think this team will be slightly better than last year; Middleton and McCollum should provide some form of stability to the offense. But the Wiz are definitely going to be bad once more. The day will come when they are a playoff team, and it will be sweet. But that is not this year.

Projected Starters

PG: Carlton “Bub” Carrington

SG: CJ McCollum

SF: Khris Middleton

PF: Kyshawn George

C: Alex Sarr

Key Bench Players: Cam Whitmore, Corey Kispert, Tre Johnson

Head Coach – Brian “Big Ole Frowny Face” Keefe

Additions – Cam Whitmore, CJ McCollum



Losses – Jordan Poole 🙄

Notable Injury – Bilal Coulibaly will miss a couple weeks to start the season following a torn thumb ligament suffered in the EuroLeague.

Breakout Candidate – Cam Whitmore: I already said a bit about Whitmore above... but I foresee him being my favorite Wizard this year. He had been forced out of playing time in Houston, but was a first-round pick and a huge HS recruit, so it was well-worth giving him a chance. The guy can put up some shots and has the ability to put up nights like these - (13/19, 7/12 3pt, 34 pts 8 reb), (10/19, 4/6 3pt, 27 pts 11 reb 2 stl 3 blk), (6/8, 3/3 3pt, 17 pts in 17 min). With that comes the other side of the spectrum, but after looking through his game logs, he actually has less of those games than I expected. He can also jump out of the gym and has some nasty dunks. I think he is capable of averaging 15+ ppg and should provide lots of highlight plays throughout the season.

Draft Picks – (6) Tre Johnson, (21) Will Riley

#15 – Brooklyn Nets

General Thoughts – I feel quite confident in pronouncing this the worst team in the NBA. I think they are historically bad... like 10-72 bad. Their lineup can be described in no other way than completely awful. First and foremost, they had FIVE first round picks in this year's remarkably weak draft. But you know, draft picks are still valuable, so I'm sure they were able to package some of them for a solid player... right? Nope! They decided to select and keep ALL FIVE! And boy did they draft some stinkers. My personal favorite is Ben Saraf, who "I can't say my S's" Jonathan Givony described at the draft as being an "Israeli D'Angelo Russell." There cannot possibly be a worse comparison than that. These rookies will be mentored by Cam Thomas and Michael Porter Jr., who will lead by example via an all-out Tug of War over the basketball. Each will be thirstily desiring 20 shots a game. Dëmin was their prized pick, but he can't shoot at all (27.3 3PT% on 4.7 attempts a game in college) and profiles as a skinny Ben Simmons. They acquired some crappy veterans in Terrance Mann and Haywood Highsmith to log some minutes for 'em. I guess if I had to give the Nets a strength, it would be at the Center position. Nic Claxton is remarkably OK, and Day'Ron Sharpe is an equally OK backup. I will be paying close attention to the Nets early in the year to determine whether they are funny bad (2024-25 Wizards) or boring bad (2024-25 Jazz), but that's about all they have to offer this season. Better hope the ping pong balls fall their way, and that AJ Dybantsa is the real deal!

Projected Starters

PG: Egor Dëmin (Pronounced YAY-gor, Deh-meen)

SG: Cam Thomas



SF: Terance Mann

PF: Michael Porter Jr.¹

C: Nic Claxton

Key Bench Players: Day'Ron Sharpe, Noah Clowney, Haywood Highsmith

- Here's a fun fact about Haywood Highsmith: On February 6th, 2024, Haywood Highsmith was driving home when he struck a man who was assisting another driver with a disabled vehicle. The man was left with critical injuries, including a partial leg amputation.

Head Coach – Jordi Fernandez

Additions – Michael Porter Jr., Terrance Mann, Haywood Highsmith, Kobe Bufkin

Losses – Cameron Johnson, Tandon Watford, D'Angelo Russell

Breakout Candidate – Michael Porter Jr. – This is going to be less of a breakout season and more so just the fact that Porter moves from 3rd option to 1a/1b. He has averaged 13.4 shots per game and 17.4 ppg over the last three seasons on what I would deem to be efficient shooting (49.2 FG%, 40.1 3PT %). His shot attempts are going to be in the 18-20 per game range, and he is a good enough pure shooter that his ppg should fall in the 25 range. These will be meaningless shots and meaningless points in meaningless games, but they count all the same. I think a big jump in PPG for Porter Jr. is virtually inevitable and I would bank on some 40 burgers from him in February for the 7-55 Nets.

Draft Picks – (8) Egor Dëmin, (19) Nolan Traore, (22) Drake Powell, (26) Ben Saraf, (27) Danny Wolf

West

#1 – Oklahoma City Thunder

General Thoughts – This is kind of an easy one to write. The defending champs bring back literally their entire roster, with no additions and no losses. Led by MVP Shai Gilgeous-Alexander, they put together a legendary season last year. Chet only played 32 regular season games, and Hartenstein only played 57, yet they hardly missed a beat. Jalen Williams is the best player in the NBA that doesn't get talked about enough. He is an absolute star, averaging

¹ MPJ is without a doubt one of the most comical players in the NBA. Denver must have been greatly censoring him, because he has been on a tear with insane quotes since he's arrived in Brooklyn. And I mean, the dude has "Never Swing the Rock" listed as an official nickname on Basketball Reference... how awesome is that??

21.6/5.3/5.1/1.6/0.7 last year. SGA free-threwed his way to the regular season MVP (which I still think Jokic should have won... voter fatigue is real), WCF MVP, and Finals MVP. They bring back the same group of dogs off the bench, led by "The Torture Chamber" Lu Dort and Alex Caruso. Their only "addition" is 2024 12th overall pick Nikola Topic, who missed a season with a torn ACL. I must say, usually a young, burgeoning dynasty is fun and I don't feel that way about OKC at all. I don't find them fun; I don't find them the slightest. Perhaps it is my disdain for foul-baiters, but I simply don't. While they are able to retain their entire roster for this season, they will face some tricky decisions... but that is for another time. They are not my favorite team, but I think they will win the most games in the regular season, will win the championship, and it would not surprise me in the slightest if they win the title.

Projected Starters

PG: Shai Gilgeous-Alexander

SG: Lu Dort

SF: Jalen Williams

PF: Chet Holmgren

C: Isaiah Hartenstein

Key Bench Players: Cason Wallace, Alex Caruso, Jaylin Williams

Head Coach – Mark Daigneault

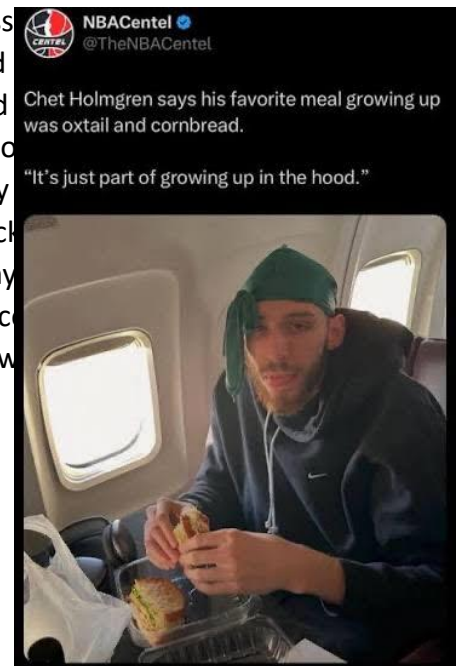
Additions – None

Losses – None

Notable Injury – Rookie Thomas Sorber will miss the entire season after tearing his ACL recently in an off-season workout.

Breakout Candidate – Nikola Topic: It's really difficult to find a breakout candidate on a proven team that brings back all their players. He is the one new piece in the puzzle, so it makes sense to pick him. They didn't really have a true backup point guard last season, which is the role he will fill this year. He has very few games with obtainable stats, but in those I could find, he was a good distributor that lacked in the 3pt department. He should see minutes in the rotation, and could be a valuable piece of the OKC second unit.

Draft Picks – (15) Thomas Sorber



#2 – Denver Nuggets

General Thoughts – I think this team has retooled beautifully. When they won the title in 2023, they had the best depth in the NBA. The last two seasons, it has slowly dwindled away, and last year their depth was horrible. This was partially due to the fact that the salaries of their stars had crowded their payroll. To combat that this offseason, they essentially swapped Michael Porter Jr. (38 million) for Cam Johnson (20.5 million)². Doing so freed up 18 million dollars of payroll, while also giving them a player of the exact same caliber, but a better fit in their system. Johnson is not a ball-dominant player, and as a career 39.2% shooter from three, he will be able to camp around the perimeter while the most effective PnR in the game (Murray & Jokic... which I absolutely love since they run it in either configuration) goes to work. The additions of former champion Bruce Brown, 9/10 or 0/10 Tim Hardaway Jr. and our beloved JV gives them a strong and versatile bench to support the starting lineup. Obviously, this team runs through the indisputable best player in the game Nikola Jokic. He found a way to further his stats even more last year, averaging a shocking 29.6/12.7/10.2/1.8/0.6 on 57.6/41.7/80.0 shooting splits. To me, it was one of the greatest statistical seasons of all time. Christian Braun took a huge leap last year, Jamal Murray was as steady as ever (go look at his stats by season... they are arguably the most consistent of any player in the league), while Aaron Gordon battled chronic calf injuries. Probably the oddest part of their season last year was the firing of coach Mike Malone directly before the playoffs. Talk about a way to throw off your mojo! Interim coach David Adelman was named Head Coach, and will look to lead this team back to the promised land. I think they are more than capable of winning it all again. Never undervalue the importance of having the best player on your team!

Projected Starters

PG: Jamal Murray

SG: Christian Braun

SF: Cameron Johnson

PF: Aaron Gordon

C: Nikola Jokic



Key Bench Players: Bruce Brown, Peyton Watson, Jonas Valančiūnas (JV!!)

Head Coach – David Adelman

Additions – Cameron Johnson, Jonas Valančiūnas, Bruce Brown, Tim Hardaway Jr.

² *Nuggets Footnote:* They also traded an unprotected 2032 1st round pick to the Nets. The player the Nets select with that pick is currently in middle school.

Losses – Michael Porter Jr., Dario Saric

Breakout Candidate – Bruce Brown: This is a tricky team to pick a breakout candidate for, since they are such a veteran and proven squad. Brown is not really a breakout per se, but rather a bounce back. He was an essential piece of their championship team, but has not seen that same success the past two seasons, due to a combination of playing on three different teams, being injured, and simply shooting worse (FG% - 48.3% 2023 -> 45.8% 2024-5 | 3PT% - 35.8% 2023 -> 32.7% 2024-5). Back in a system where he feels comfortable and where Jokic makes it easy on everybody, I'd expect Brown to put up numbers aligning with his 2022-23 production again.

Draft Picks – No Notables

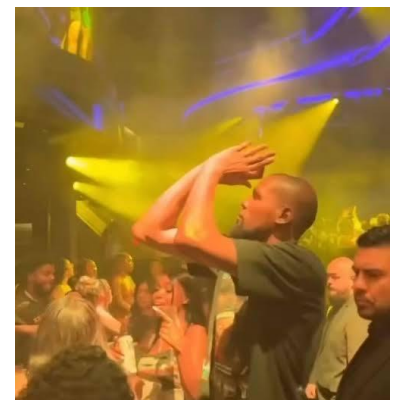
#3 – Houston Rockets

General Thoughts – I absolutely love what the Rockets did in the offseason. I have been clamoring for them to get rid of locker room cancer Jalen Green for several years and somehow, they were able to spin him as the key piece in a trade for Kevin Durant! It goes without saying that adding Kevin Durant to your team helps immensely. At 36, he was good as ever last year, putting up 26.6 ppg on incredibly efficient shooting (52.7/43.0/83.9). Last year they were the best defensive and rebounding team in the league, but had trouble scoring on occasion, which is a weakness Durant should be able to help fix. They have unbelievable size and length... I mean just look at this stable of demons: Amen Thompson (6'7", 7 ft wingspan), Kevin Durant (6'11", 7 ft 5 wingspan), Jabari Smith Jr. (6'11", 7 ft 1 wingspan), Dorian Finney-Smith (6'7", 7 ft wingspan), Tari Eason (6'8", 7 ft 2 wingspan), Josh Okogie (6'4", 7 ft wingspan). I don't think it takes an amazing prediction to say I think they will be the best defensive team once more. However, losing Fred Van Vleet for the season is a devastating blow to their championship hopes. I am not high on him as an individual, but the Rockets guard room is really thin, and they have no cap space to sign a free agent (like Russ or Ben Simmons). They will have to make do with the tandem of Reed Sheppard/Aaron Holiday running point, or get creative with some gargantuan lineups that may contain 35 feet of arms. Ime Udoka is a phenomenal coach who can get the absolute most out of his players, so I believe in him to figure something out. Also, just to reiterate, I cannot emphasize enough how important it was for them to rid themselves of Jalen Green... and Dillon Brooks too. There will be no theatrics in Houston this year, just some old-school hardball. They were going to be my pick to win it all prior to the FVV injury, but now I have concerns. Regardless, I still think they have a dangerous roster that will win a lot of games and threaten in the playoffs.

Projected Starters

PG: Reed Sheppard

SG: Amen Thompson



SF: Kevin Durant

PF: Jabari Smith Jr.

C: Alperen Sengun

Key Bench Players: Dorian Finney-Smith, Tari Eason, Steven Adams

Head Coach – Ime Udoka

Additions – Kevin Durant, Dorian Finney-Smith, Clint Capela, Josh Okogie

Losses – Jalen Green, Dillon Brooks, Cam Whitmore

Notable Injury – Fred VanVleet has suffered a torn ACL and will miss the entire season.

Breakout Candidate – Reed Sheppard: Despite being the 3rd overall pick, Sheppard had difficulty finding playing time last season. With other guards Jalen Green, Dillon Brooks, and Cam Whitmore on different teams, and FVV out for the season, there are more minutes to go around. Sheppard is an ELITE shooter, and on a roster that is still somewhat lacking in the 3pt department, I suspect he will be an integral piece of this team. Even with FVV out, I don't see Sheppard running too much point guard. Amen Thompson ran point when VanVleet sat last year, so Sheppard should be able to play shooting guard and camp out in the corner. I think he could average 1.5-2.0 threes per game on 40% 3pt shooting, which is a skill that no one else on the Rockets bench has to offer.

Draft Picks – No Notables

#4 – Minnesota Timberwolves

General Thoughts – Well, they were my pick to win it all last year and I was not correct. They put together a solid season, losing in the WCF for the 2nd consecutive season. With no additions whatsoever, and only one meaningful departure (NAW), the Wolves should be a dangerous squad once more. NAW was a great defender, but I don't care what the statistics say, I NEVER saw that man make a three. His production should be replaced by sophomore guards Rob Dillingham and Terrance Shannon Jr. Both offer tremendous upside, and should they take a leap, it could really elevate their team. Ant decided to hoist up threes last year at a remarkable rate (10.3 per game!) but still managed to shoot 39.5% from downtown. Despite that, I still think he needs to shoot less threes this year. I've heard he's been working on a mid-post game this offseason, which could unlock the third level of scoring to truly make him unstoppable. King Julius settled into his new climate nicely, improving his percentages across the board, albeit scoring less ppg. DiVincenzo did not settle quite as nicely, struggling immensely early in the year (39.7% FG pct in the first half). The Stifle Tower (Rudy Gobert) and Naz "Jelly Fam" Reid complete the big man trilogy, one of the best in the league. To me, the Timberwolves are one of

the most exciting teams to watch, and not just because of my love for the team, but because they are filled with some of the most dynamic and easy-to-root-for players. They have been unable to get over the hump in past seasons. I'm not sure if they will win the finals or win it all, but should any top seed falter, Minnesota

Projected Starters

PG: Mike Conley

SG: Anthony Edwards

SF: Jaden McDaniels

PF: Julius Randle

C: Rudy Gobert

Key Bench Players: Donte "Big Ragu" DiVincenzo, Naz Reid, Terrance Shannon Jr.

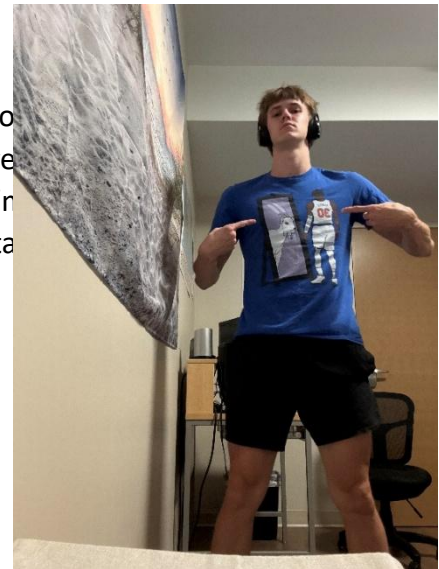
Head Coach – Chris Finch

Additions – None

Losses – Nickeil Alexander-Walker

Breakout Candidate – Rob Dillingham – I was clamoring for Dillingham to get more minutes all season last year, but it never happened. At some point, the Wolves are going to have to give him the reins at PG and tell ancient Mike Conley to take a seat on the bench. He was pretty bad last season, and I mean the idea of a backcourt of Rob and Mike Conley (his IG handle) and Ant Edwards is phenomenal. Should he be given the opportunity, I would expect Dillingham to infuse this starting lineup in a big way, and could be the piece that is missing. I know I'll be rooting for him!

Draft Picks – (17) Joan Beringer



#5 – Dallas Mavericks

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

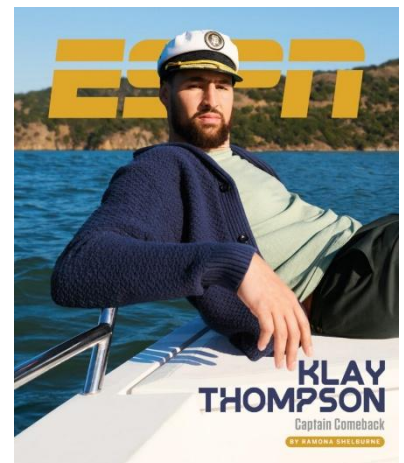
PG: D'Angelo Russell

SG: Klay Thompson

SF: Cooper Flagg

PF: Anthony Davis

C: Dereck Lively



Key Bench Players: PJ Washington, Daniel Gafford, Max Christie

Head Coach – Jason Kidd

Additions – D’Angelo Russell

Losses – None

Notable Injury – Kyrie Irving will miss all of the season following a torn ACL.

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – (1) Cooper Flagg

#6 – Golden State Warriors

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: Steph Curry

SG: Buddy Hield

SF: Jimmy Butler III

PF: Draymond Green

C: Al Horford

Key Bench Players: Moses Moody, Quinten Post, Jonathan Kuminga

Head Coach – Steve Kerr

Additions – Al Horford, Seth Curry

Losses – Kevon Looney

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – No Notables



#7 – Los Angeles Lakers

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: Luka Dončić



SG: Austin Reaves

SF: Rui Hachimura

PF: LeBron James

C: Deandre Ayton

Key Bench Players: Marcus Smart, Jake LaRavia, Jarred Vanderbilt

Head Coach – JJ Redick

Additions – Deandre Ayton, Jake LaRavia, Marcus Smart

Losses – Dorian Finney-Smith

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – (36) Adou Thiero

#8 – Los Angeles Clippers

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: James Harden

SG: Bradley Beal

SF: Kawhi Leonard

PF: John Collins

C: Ivica Zubac



Key Bench Players: Chris Paul, Nicolas Batum, Brook “Loves Disney World” Lopez

Head Coach – Tyronn Lue

Additions – John Collins, Bradley Beal, Brook Lopez, Chris Paul

Losses – Norman Powell

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – (30) Yanic Konan Niederhauser

- By far the best name in the draft

#9 – San Antonio Spurs

General Thoughts –

Projected Starters

PG: De'Aaron Fox

SG: Stephon Castle

SF: Devin Vassell

PF: Harrison Barnes

C: Victor Wembanyama

Key Bench Players: Dylan Harper, Jeremy Sochan, Luke Kornet

Head Coach – Mitch Johnson

Additions – Luke Kornet, Kelly Olynyk

Losses – Chris Paul, Sandro Mamukelashvili

Breakout Candidate –

Draft Picks – (2) Dylan Harper, (14) Carter Bryant



#10 – Sacramento Kings

General Thoughts – After being the #3 seed in 2022-23, the Kings have regressed each of the last two seasons, putting together a losing record last year. What was one of the league's most beautiful offenses to watch was completely ruined by the signing of DeMar DeRozan and the subsequent trading of De'Aaron Fox to San Antonio. With trade acquisition Zach LaVine as well, the offense no longer revolves around Sabonis at the high post, but rather has devolved into gross iso-ball. This was exemplified by Sabonis' regression in assists (8.2 in 2023-24, 6.0 in 2024-25). Now, what was a budding young team has turned into a mosh pit of mediocrity. Trading De'Aaron Fox was a sad move typical of a cheap, bad franchise. There was no motive for the trade other than the fact that they did not want to sign him to an extension. San Antonio gladly swooped in and gave him a 4-year extension. LaVine and DeRozan clearly did not work together in Chicago, putting together many below average seasons, so pairing them together again is odd. It also blocks Keon Ellis and Devin Carter, who are both young, do-it-all players that will now lose minutes and come off the bench. Keegan Murray put together a real stinker of a year last year following high expectations (I hated him... he was on my fantasy team). Their bench is remarkably thin, especially in the big man department. They are going to have to hope for their first-round pick Nique Clifford to repeat his summer league performance, where he averaged

15.2/6.5/4.2 on 49.3% FG and 45.8% 3PT. This team is by no means bad; they still have several high-caliber names on their roster. But they are inferior to what they were only a few years ago, and I see them having no higher potential than making the play-in games.

Projected Starters

PG: Malik Monk

SG: Zach LaVine

SF: DeMar DeRozan

PF: Keegan Murray

C: Domantas Sabonis



Key Bench Players: Dennis Schröder, Keon Ellis, Nique Clifford

Head Coach – Doug Christie

Additions – Dennis Schroder, Dario Saric, Drew Eubanks

Losses – Jonas Valanciunas

Breakout Candidate – Devin Carter: Carter, the Kings 2024 first round pick (13) was injured coming into last season, only playing 36 games. He did not do well at all, but I think a disjoint rookie season is to blame for that. It is hard enough to find your footing as a rookie, let alone when you are rehabbing the entire first half of the season. He was a really good player in college, a grit and grind type. Despite only being 6'3", he averaged 8.7 rpg and a block a game his final season at Providence, along with 20 ppg. I'm not sure how much he will get to play early in the year as the 5th guard on the depth chart. However, Dennis Schroder has been traded 3 of the last 4 years at the deadline (he was so angered by this last season that he compared the trade deadline to "modern slavery"), and Zach LaVine is someone who could also be moved, so I expect his minutes to increase as the year goes on. I have no clue what his stats may look like, but he is a winning player that can contribute in a lot of different ways, and I think he will show that this year for the Kings.

Draft Picks – (24) Nique Clifford, (42) Maxime Raynaud

- This was the hardest team to find a funny image for. I could not think of anything funny about them. The context behind this picture is that in the "Starting 5" docuseries, Domantas Sabonis was one of the five players featured. We quite liked his family. To quote my dad on 10/23/24 – "You haven't seen the next generation of Sabonis – Tigey... or his gold-digging wife." I figured in their honor; I would find a lovely Sabonis family portrait.

#11 – Memphis Grizzlies

General Thoughts – The Grizzlies aren't getting off to a good start! Somehow, they are already ravaged by injuries... and they haven't played a single game! Zach Edey is hurt, Jaren Jackson Jr. is hurt, Brandon Clarke is hurt, and then Ja Morant just sprained his ankle earlier today (10/6) and is questionable for the start of the season. This is a team who lost a lot of valuable role players in the offseason, while also trading away one of their key names in Desmond Bane. The tricky part is that even when this team is fully healthy, I still don't think they are good. Ja's numbers were down across the board last year, and between injuries and suspensions for brandishing weapons on social media, he can never seem to stay on the floor. Jaren Jackson Jr. puts up impressive, well-rounded stats each season, but I really just do not think that duo is anywhere near good enough to lead a contending team. Their starting lineup is filled out with Jaylen Wells who, despite finishing 3rd in ROTY voting, had a very unimpressive season (10.4 pts, 3.4 reb, 42.5% FG) and Kentavious Caldwell-Pope who shot horribly last year. They traded up in the draft to select Cedric Coward, who played only 6 games at Washington State last year and was someone I had never heard of until about two days before the draft. I can't imagine he'll be good. Wells also went to Washington State... perhaps they are trying to start a streak. The rest of their bench is remarkably uninspiring, barring their FA signing of my beloved Ty Jerome. He signed with them for less money than I thought he would following his huge breakout year. If/when Morant misses time, he should have opportunities to be the starting PG. I am having trouble finding anything else to remark on about this team. It's a boring roster that is not all that talented, and I have a hard time imagining them being any better than a play-in team and would expect them to miss the playoffs entirely.

Projected Starters

PG: Ja Morant

SG: Kentavious Caldwell-Pope

SF: Jaylen Wells

PF: Jaren Jackson Jr.

C: Santi "The Trolley Problem" Aldama*\

Key Bench Players: Ty Jerome, Vince Williams Jr., Jock Landale

Head Coach – Tuomas Iisalo

Additions – Ty Jerome, Kentavious Caldwell-Pope

Losses – Desmond Bane, Luke Kennard, Jay Huff, Jake LaRavia

Notable Injury – Zach Edey will miss a couple weeks to start the season following off-season ankle surgery. (Big men and foot problems... kiss of death)



Jaren Jackson Jr. will miss 1-3 weeks to start the season following a procedure to repair turf toe.

Breakout Candidate – Santi Aldama*: With three Grizzlies big men starting the season injured, Aldama should see all the minutes he can handle early on. I'd like to note that he is much taller than I thought... he is 6'11"! I would have guessed 6'8". Aldama improved his numbers across the board last season, averaging 12.5 pts. 6.4 reb and 1.8 threes per game. In the 16 games where he played 30+ minutes, he averaged 16.4/8.3/3.9 with 2.3 threes per game. Their big man room is so thin that Aldama is currently listed as the starting C and the backup PF (behind JJJ who is likely to miss games to start the year). I expect him to eclipse the 30-minute threshold a lot and see no reason why he can't put up numbers for the season similar to the aforementioned slash line. Keep an eye out for the Trolley Problem!

- For some reason, there was a trend on Tiktok around January/February 2025 where users started giving nicknames to every single NBA player. Most of them were terrible, but Aldama was given the nickname of "The Trolley Problem" and I really liked that one. I haven't called him anything other than his new nickname since then.

Draft Picks – (11) Cedric Coward

#12 – Phoenix Suns

General Thoughts – Despite paying \$150 million to the "Big Three" of Kevin Durant, Bradley Beal and Devin Booker, the Suns went 36-46 and missed the playoffs entirely. Going into this season, only 1/3 of the trio remains (although they are paying Beal \$53 million to NOT play for them). They dealt Kevin Durant to the Rockets and flat-out waived Bradley Beal. In return for Durant, they received Jalen Green and Dillon Brooks, along with the pick that turned into Khaman Maluach. Now they have an entire roster of shooting guards. Dillon Brooks is currently their projected PF, standing at 6'6". They are going to run Booker at PG as well. I really hate Jalen Green, and think he is going to play "like a bat out of Hades" to quote Jeremy Hartman. On a Rockets team where he was the 4th or 5th best player, he managed to shoot so many shots (17.5 per game) that he was 5th in the **ENTIRE NBA** in shots attempted. This Suns roster, barring Booker, has zero shot creating ability, so I'm sure Green will be hoisting up gobs of shots once more. Royce O'Neale, Dillon Brooks, Grayson Allen and Ryan Dunn form a conglomerate of solid but limited role players who will likely be playing more minutes than they should. No winning team would have 2 of those 4 in the starting lineup, but that will likely be the case almost every night. One other move they made in the offseason was trading for the chronically injured Mark Williams. He is super talented and his numbers have improved each season. The problem is that he has played 106 games in 3 years. Heck, he is SO injury-prone that a trade was made public, then rescinded because of his physical. That is the only instance I can recall that happening in my lifetime! I suppose there is a chance they strike gold and get Williams to play 65+ games,

but the more likely outcome is WAY too many minutes for the baby deer Khaman Maluach. I want the guy to be good as he is super likeable, but I just can't see that happening... especially not in year 1. I am not a fan of the Suns roster. It is veteran-laden enough to where there is a chance they finish right at .500 and make the play-in, but I do not see their potential being any higher.

Projected Starters

PG: Devin Booker

SG: Jalen Green

SF: Royce O'Neale

PF: Dillon Brooks

C: Mark Williams

Key Bench Players: Ryan Dunn, Grayson Allen, Khaman Maluach

Head Coach – Jordan Ott

Additions – Jalen Green, Mark Williams, Dillon Brooks, Jared Butler, Jordan Goodwin

Losses – Kevin Durant, Bradley Beal, Tyus Jones

Breakout Candidate – Oso Ighodaro: On a roster without much size, a ticking time bomb at Center, and a 19-year-old backup C who picked up a basketball for the first time about 4 years ago, the Suns could be in a sticky situation very quickly. Ighodaro got some opportunities last year with the Suns C carousel, but nothing consistent. He was a great player at Marquette, serving as the complement to Tyler Kolek. Last year he averaged 4.2/3.6 on 17 min per game. I think his minutes will be in a similar range to start the season, but there is a scenario where Williams immediately gets hurt, and he is thrust directly into the starting lineup by default. Should he find himself in this spot, I think he can double his production from last year. An average statline of 10 pts, 8 reb and 1 block per game is something I would expect to see from Ighodaro this season.

Draft Picks – (10) Khaman Maluach, (31) Rasheer Fleming, (41) Koby Brea



#13 – New Orleans Pelicans

General Thoughts – I fell victim to believing in the Pelicans last year, picking them to finish 3rd in the West. That was not remotely close to what happened. Instead, their whole team got injured once again and they finished 14th. As the old adage goes: Fool me once, shame on you... fool me twice, shame on me. I will not be fooled twice. Their big offseason move was trading for Jordan Poole. We all know how I feel about Poole, but I don't like this fit for him. With Dejounte Murray

missing at least half of the season, Poole is slotted in to be their PG. He is not a point guard whatsoever, and I don't think this will be a role he thrives in. On paper, their starting lineup still looks pretty good. But the trio of Trey Murphy/Herb Jones/Supposedly skinnier Zion Williamson can never stay healthy, and it is rare to see even 2 of them out there together. To compliment this injury-prone starting lineup, they have possibly the worst second unit in the NBA. Jordan Hawkins is a mega-chucker (37.2% FG last year), Saddiq Bey spent the whole year injured on the Wizards bench, and Kevon Looney is the most limited player ever (Also, he is somehow only 29 years old... that is shocking!) I do not like either of their draft picks at all. Jeremiah Fears is only 19 years old, skinny, and wildly inconsistent. As a 6'4" guard, he shot 28.4% from three last year, and had games where he completely disappeared. Derik Queen was super fun to watch at Maryland, and I understand that players with his build are becoming more prosperous in the NBA, but I still have little faith. You have to be so good to cover up a complete lack of athleticism that I will never believe it until I see it. Also, every one of those players that is good is European... Queen is not. This is a team that possesses some talent, but they always underperform, so I shall not be fooled again!

Projected Starters

PG: Jordan Poole

SG: Trey Murphy III

SF: Herb Jones

PF: Zion Williamson

C: Yves Missi

Key Bench Players: Jeremiah Fears, Derik Queen, Saddiq Bey

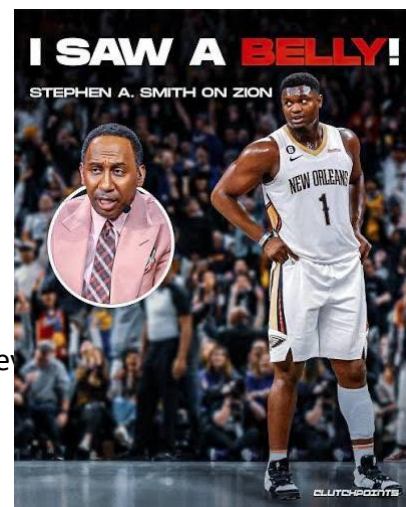
Head Coach – Willie Green

Additions – Jordan Poole, Saddiq Bey, Kevon Looney

Losses – CJ McCollum, Bruce Brown, Kelly Olynyk

Notable Injury – Dejounte Murray: Will be out until at least January while recovering from a torn Achilles.

Breakout Candidate – N/A: Rather than stretching to find someone that I think may breakout, I'm just going to "keep it 100%." I see nobody with breakout potential on this roster. Their starting lineup is full of proven players who have shown their top potential, and their bench is full of dregs that I have no faith in. Yves Missi best fits the profile of a player I would choose to breakout, as I like picking 2nd year players. However, he ascertained the starting C job almost immediately (67 starts, 26.8 mpg). In this role, he did rather well (9.1 ppg, 8.2 rpg, 1.3 bpg).



However, I think that is simply his capability as a player. I would be surprised to see his numbers jump way up this year, and would expect them to be in a very similar realm to last season.

Draft Picks – (7) Jeremiah Fears, (13) Derik Queen, (40) Micah Peavy

#14 – Portland Trailblazers

General Thoughts – I have no clue what this team is up to. Their roster construction is bizarre. Let's start with their offseason moves. They got rid of locker room cancer Deandre Ayton, which was a good thing. They dealt prolific chucker Anfernee Simons to Boston, another seemingly good thing. But their return was... only 35-year-old Jrue Holiday?? Why on earth would they want him? He is still under contract for 3 years, \$104.4 million, which is appalling given he showed significant signs of regression last year. On top of that, they signed a 35-year-old Dame Lillard who will miss all of 2025-26 to a 3-year, \$41 million contract. And... that was it? Those were their two additions. Gross. Not to mention they still owe Jerami Grant \$102.4 million over the next three seasons. They are supposedly building around a young core which is proving to be filled with failed picks like Scoot Henderson and Shaedon Sharpe. Deni Avdija is only 24 despite feeling much older, and seems to be an empty stat guy. Toumani Camara was a bright spot for last year's squad, making second team All-Defense (The Trailblazers Instagram account put out maybe the coolest edit I've ever seen for Camara to announce this. If you can find it, it was incredible). In yet another confusing decision, with Donovan Clingan projecting to be their starting center for years to come, the Trailblazers decided to draft another center with their first-round pick in June. Not just any center... Yang Hansen! Hansen was not even in the draft room; he just emerged from the rafters of the Barclays Center to walk down and shake Adam "The Mutant" Silver's hand. This pick shocked me, it shocked everyone in my twitter feed, and it especially shocked the 12 black women who were on the ESPN draft show. I have no direction, I have no understanding of their goals or future plans right down here in the cellar with Utah for the whole season.

Projected Starters

PG: Jrue Holiday

SG: Shaedon Sharpe

SF: Deni Avdija

PF: Toumani Camara

C: Donovan Clingan

Key Bench Players: Scoot Henderson, Jerami Grant, Yang Hansen

Head Coach – Chauncey Billups



Additions – Jrue Holiday, Damian Lillard

Losses – Anfernee Simons, Deandre Ayton

Notable Injuries – Damian Lillard will miss the entire season due to a torn achilles. Scoot Henderson will miss 4-6 weeks with a left hamstring tear.

Breakout Candidate – Donovan Clingan: This is one of the least adventurous of my breakout candidates. Clingan was stuffed behind Deandre Ayton last season, but after ridding themselves of that dead weight, Portland sees Clingan as their center of the future. He was given opportunities last season, albeit with inconsistency. His play was inconsistent as well, but he showed definite promise. Per 36 minutes, he averaged 11.9 ppg, 14.3 rpg (6 oreb per game), and 3 bpg last year. I don't expect him to average those numbers this season, but I think he can average a double-double with 2 blocks per game. The dude is simply a monstrous human, 7'2" 280 lbs! He struggled a lot with foul trouble (5.1 per 36 min... yikes!), presumably because he is slow and was getting roped into PnR on the perimeter. There are parts of his game which need definite refinement, but he showed plenty of promise in his rookie year, and should take a big sophomore leap.

Draft Picks – (16) Yang Hansen

- He wins the award of "player I most want to watch from this year's class." Watching the humongous Asian emerge from the crowd at the draft was incredible. I think I let loose a Baby Waker

#15 – Utah Jazz

General Thoughts – This is undoubtedly the worst team in the West. What a disgusting roster. A team that went 17-65 last season got considerably worse in my opinion. They willingly parted ways with Jordan Clarkson, John Collins and Collin Sexton, who are all solid NBA players... replacing them with almost no one. Their "additions" are just throw-ins they received in trades. None of them will be on the roster post-trade deadline. They owe Lauri Markkanen \$195 million over the next 4 seasons, so they have faith that they can build around him as their star player. I do not share this same faith. His numbers regressed a solid amount last season (23.2 ppg -> 19.0 ppg, 8.2 rpg -> 5.9 rpg, 39.9 3pt % -> 34.6 3pt %), putting his counting stats at the level of player I consider him to be. Keyonte George has solidified himself as one of the best chuckers in the NBA, shooting 39% from the field in consecutive seasons. Isaiah Collier actually came on strong after the All Star Break last season, averaging 12 ppg and 7 apg. He showed them enough that they cleared out their other guards, giving him the reigns at the point guard spot. They took Ace Bailey with the 5th pick, who was the best pick they could make at the time. He has the build of Kevin Durant/Brandon Ingram/Brandon Miller, and certainly has great upside. However, he was openly against being drafted by the Jazz prior to the draft, and appeared slightly to severely stupid... so I'm not holding out too much hope. They traded up to the 18th pick (with

our beloved Wizards) to nab March Madness Legend Walter Clayton Jr. I hope he is successful in the NBA; he certainly has the ability to light up the scoring column. All in all, this team needs and will likely be in contention for the #1 pick in next year's draft. If they want to maintain the sustained health of Markkanen and Kessler, along with stark development, that will be paramount.

Projected Starters

PG: Isaiah Collier

SG: Keyonte George

SF: Ace Bailey

PF: Lauri Markkanen

C: Walker Kessler

Key Bench Players: Brice Sensabaugh, Taylor Hendricks, Kyle Filipowski

Head Coach – Will Hardy

Additions – Kyle Anderson, Georges Niang, Jusuf Nurkic

Losses – Jordan Clarkson, John Collins, Collin Sexton

Breakout Candidate – Taylor Hendricks: Hendricks somehow suffered a non-contact injury last year where he broke his fibula and also dislocated his ankle (I unfortunately saw the video of this... it was disgusting) in the third game of the season last year, cutting his sophomore campaign very short. However, the 2023 9th overall pick showed promise in the 2nd half of the 2023-24 season, averaging 9.3 ppg, 5.9 rpg, and nearly a steal and block per game. He will likely come off the bench early in the year, but should see regular minutes and I'd expect him to have a large role on the tanking Jazz in the second half of the season.

Draft Picks – (5) Ace Bailey, (18) Walter Clayton Jr.

- Based on what I saw at the Draft, Ace Bailey appeared to be Scottie Barnes 2.0 in the "on the spectrum" department.

